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When Is a Chalk Bring-Back Worth It?

MIKE LEONE // SEP 3, 2026 CINCINNATI BENGALS, JA'MARR CHASE, IN-
SEASON PACKAGE



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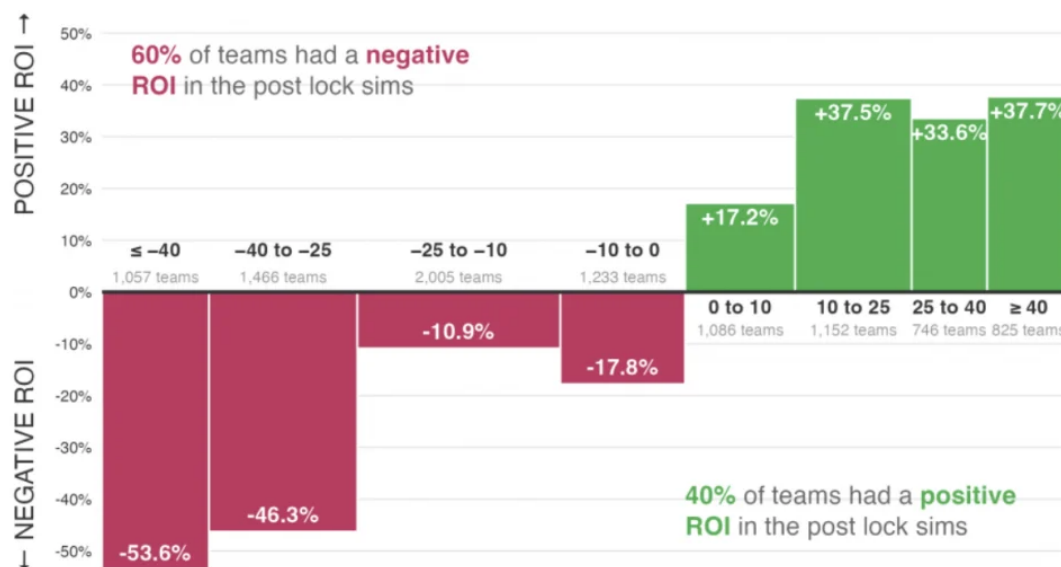
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Earlier this offseason, I wrote an article titled *[Putting the Sims to the Test](#)*. The goal of that article was to evaluate the efficacy of the post-lock sims at [The Solver](#). The results were positive. The sims were directionally accurate at predicting cash rates, top-10 finish rates, and ROI. The simulated ROI, the most important metric, was more volatile than the other metrics, but it clearly showed that the teams with better simulated ROIs had better actual ROIs. I did warn in that article against “sim hacking” (i.e., trying to break the sims to find the best possible simulated ROI). There appears to be a simulated ROI threshold beyond which all positively simulated teams are similarly strong in practice and difficult to distinguish from one another.

ROI Outcomes



Plot shows actual ROI for teams grouped by their post lock sim ROI bucket. Bar widths are proportionate to the number of teams within each bucket.



Source: Michael Leone

In today's article, I'm using the post-lock sims to evaluate one specific element of game stacking: whether to include the obvious opposing bring-back. Several slates last year made me **wonder if chalk bring-backs were overplayed by the field**. All else equal, more positive correlation improves a DFS lineup. But all else is not equal. Even good strategies in a vacuum can turn into -EV strategies if too many of our opponents implement them. It's the same reason why the best-projected RB value on a slate could be a bad tournament play.

When the Chalk Bring-Back Is +EV

The slate that had me thinking about this was Week 9. CIN-CHI game stacks were popular; the game had a 51.5-point total, the second-highest mark on the slate. **D'Andre Swift** was out for the Bears, making **Kyle Monangai** a key value on the slate. **Caleb Williams** was our second-best

QB value, but much more stackable than the top QB value (**Jaxson Dart**). **Ja'Marr Chase** was our top projected WR, both in raw total points and in value.

Before the slate, I was talking to Drew Dinkmeyer about a few simulated Bears-stack lineups that looked good after swapping the slightly lower-projected **Puka Nacua** in for **Ja'Marr Chase**. We both dismissed the idea as preposterous; it went against everything we've been taught as DFS players. Sacrifice projection *and* correlation? No way.

Ironically, despite the game shooting out (47-42), Chase came incredibly close to failing. He ended up with 20.1 DraftKings points, but 5.3 of those came when he achieved the bonus on the second-to-last play of the game. **Puka Nacua** had almost the reverse outcome. He scored in the first half and seemed destined for a huge day. The game ended in a blowout, however, and Puka wound up five yards short of the bonus but still scored 22.5 DraftKings points. He still outscored Chase, but not in a meaningful way.

The way the games unfolded showed how Puka could lap Chase while the Bears stacks still succeeded, giving those lineups substantial leverage over the field.

In the Game Changer, I played Chase with my Caleb stack and finished with the highest post-lock simulated ROI — good for plenty of Sklansky bucks but \$0 in actual winnings, while the second-highest post-lock sim ROI team won first place:

Week		Site - Game Type		Slate		Contest									
Week 9 - 2025		DraftKings - Classic		Sun 11/2 1:00 PM - 11 Games		\$1500 \$400K Game Changer (282 entries) Updated 11/2 10:41 PM		Avg Sim ROI: 6.15% Median Sim ROI: 6.08%							
	RANK	POINTS	PRIZE	USER NAME	LINEUP							↓ SIM ROI	CASH RATE		
	174	141.78		leonem	C. Williams	J. Warren	T. Tracy Jr.	J. Chase	R. Odunze	D. Moore	T. Warren	K. Monangai	Jaguars	51%	28%
	1	227.88	\$100,000.00	Grext123	C. Williams	C. McCaffrey	J. Warren	J. Chase	D. Moore	O. Zaccheaus	B. Bowers	K. Monangai	49ers	49%	30%
	60	172.40	\$2,500.00	sullybrochill	C. Williams	J. Warren	K. Monangai	J. Chase	R. Odunze	O. Zaccheaus	K. Pitts Sr.	C. McCaffrey	Texa	36%	27%
	75	168.30		JGCANYON	C. Williams	C. McCaffrey	K. Monangai	J. Chase	R. Odunze	P. Washington	T. Johnson	T. Henderson		33%	30%
	238	125.80		TheeVault	C. Williams	J. Warren	T. Tracy Jr.	J. Chase	R. Odunze	J. Jennings	T. Warren	T. Henderson	Rams	31%	26%
	42	180.58	\$3,000.00	beershere	C. Williams	C. McCaffrey	K. Monangai	J. Chase	D. Moore	O. Zaccheaus	G. Kittle	K. Vidal	Texans	24%	28%
	100	161.50		jsw2nd1979	C. Williams	J. Warren	K. Monangai	P. Nacua	R. Odunze	D. Brown	H. Henry	C. McCaffrey	Bills	23%	24%
	22	192.20	\$3,500.00	Dubbleb2	C. Williams	T. Tracy Jr.	K. Monangai	P. Nacua	J. Chase	J. Jennings	B. Bowers	T. Henderson	Bronco	19%	31%
	7	209.10	\$7,000.00	Mantas85	C. Williams	C. McCaffrey	T. Etienne Jr.	N. Collins	D. London	S. Diggs	T. Johnson	K. Monangai	Falco	17%	22%
	31	187.48	\$3,000.00	nuckfuggets	C. Williams	C. McCaffrey	K. Monangai	J. Chase	D. Moore	P. Washington	T. Kelce	K. Vidal	Falcons	17%	27%
	261	119.00		Dinkpiece	C. Williams	K. Vidal	T. Tracy Jr.	J. Chase	R. Odunze	J. Jennings	T. Warren	K. Monangai	Jaguars	13%	27%
	14	197.50	\$5,000.00	Clcima6709	C. Williams	C. McCaffrey	K. Monangai	P. Nacua	J. Chase	J. Jennings	T. Johnson	P. Washington	Fal	12%	32%
	209	133.88		CoachS111	C. Williams	T. Henderson	K. Monangai	J. Chase	R. Odunze	D. Moore	T. Warren	K. Vidal	Giants	11%	24%
	26	189.20	\$3,500.00	Vachehv	C. Williams	C. McCaffrey	K. Monangai	J. Chase	C. Dike	O. Zaccheaus	T. Kelce	K. Williams	Rams	10%	25%
	214	132.38		jmac1014	C. Williams	J. Warren	T. Tracy Jr.	R. Rice	R. Odunze	D. Moore	T. Warren	A. Jeanty	Saints	7%	20%
	5	210.78	\$10,000.00	hixx	C. Williams	T. Henderson	K. Monangai	J. Chase	D. Moore	D. Brown	B. Bowers	C. McCaffrey	Patriot	7%	25%
	193	137.40		OneDropKing	C. Williams	J. Warren	K. Monangai	J. Chase	R. Odunze	D. Metcalf	T. Johnson	R. Rice	Giants	5%	24%
	20	193.40	\$4,000.00	AmedRosario1	C. Williams	C. McCaffrey	K. Monangai	J. Chase	R. Odunze	P. Washington	C. Loveland	T. Henderson		5%	25%
	107	159.90		ylksco	C. Williams	K. Vidal	K. Monangai	B. Thomas Jr.	L. McConkey	D. Metcalf	B. Bowers	K. Williams	Char	4%	25%
	61	172.28	\$2,500.00	skoal80	C. Williams	T. Henderson	K. Monangai	J. Chase	R. Odunze	D. Moore	G. Kittle	T. Higgins	Rams	1%	21%
	188	138.50		rekyt	C. Williams	T. Tracy Jr.	K. Monangai	R. Rice	R. Odunze	T. Higgins	T. Warren	K. Vidal	Raiders	1%	21%

If we look at only the Caleb teams in the tournament, here are the highest-owned WRs and their mean post-lock sim ROI:

Players (22)	Player Stacks (27)	Game Stacks (28)	Team Stacks (12)	W. ▼
Search...	☒ Show FLEX		Avg ROI	Ownership
▼ 	Ja'Marr Chase \$8.4K	WR	12%	66%
▼ 	Rome Odunze \$6.6K	WR	9%	53%
▼ 	DJ Moore \$5.2K	WR	12%	34%
		WR		31%
		FLEX		3%
▼ 	P. Washington \$3.7K	WR	2%	22%
		FLEX		6%
		WR		16%
▼ 	Jauan Jennings \$4.3K	WR	10%	19%
		WR		16%
		FLEX		3%
▼ 	O. Zaccheaus \$3.3K	WR	11%	19%
▼ 	Rashee Rice \$7.6K	WR	-9%	19%
		WR		16%
		FLEX		3%
▼ 	DK Metcalf \$5.5K	WR	-1%	16%
		WR		13%
		FLEX		3%
▼ 	Tee Higgins \$5.9K	WR	-1%	13%
		FLEX		3%
		WR		9%
▼ 	Puka Nacua \$8.5K	WR	10%	13%

Chase's ownership ballooned to 66% on Caleb teams, while Puka's fell to just 13%. Yet their simulated ROIs remained similar, even slightly favoring Chase despite his roughly 5x ownership. On this particular slate, Chase

deserved the huge increase in ownership, and there are a few reasons for that:

1. He was the best WR play on the slate in a vacuum (top raw and value projection).
2. The swap to Nacua allowed for a ton of direct 1-on-1 leverage, but it didn't make any change whatsoever to the rest of the lineup (more on this later).
3. Although Chase was a popular bring-back on Caleb teams, Caleb himself wasn't overly owned. He was actually the fourth-highest-owned QB in this contest at 11%, which reduced the need for galaxy-braining leverage around him.

Retesting all the potential lineups I made that week against the ACTUAL field yielded similar results:

Players (24)

STACKS

Player (43)Game (38)Team (12)

WR

Search...

Show FLEX

It's worth noting that Puka over Chase teams didn't simulate *poorly*. The sims certainly believed they were viable, and that the ownership of the two on Caleb teams was close to equilibrium.

Chase on non-Caleb teams had a negative mean post-lock sim ROI. Of 15 non-Caleb QBs played in the contest, Chase had a positive mean ROI on only four (and two of those were at +1%).

		STACKS			QB	
Players (17)		Player (79)	Game (91)	Team (18)		
Search...		Show FLEX				
				Avg ROI	Ownership	
▼	⊖	 Ja'Marr Chase	WR	\$8.4K	0%	0%
▼	⊖	 T. Lawrence	QB	\$5.4K	57%	2%
▼	⊖	 Mac Jones	QB	\$5.0K	19%	13%
▼	⊖	 Caleb Williams	QB	\$5.7K	12%	16%
▼	⊖	 Tyler Shough	QB	\$4.4K	1%	1%
▼	⊖	 Jaxson Dart	QB	\$5.2K	1%	30%
▼	⊖	 Justin Herbert	QB	\$6.8K	-7%	2%
▼	⊖	 Joe Flacco	QB	\$5.6K	-7%	6%
▼	⊖	 P. Mahomes	QB	\$7.1K	-8%	9%
▼	⊖	 Jared Goff	QB	\$6.0K	-17%	2%
▼	⊖	 C.J. Stroud	QB	\$5.1K	-18%	1%
▼	⊖	 Daniel Jones	QB	\$6.2K	-19%	10%
▼	⊖	 Geno Smith	QB	\$4.6K	-21%	3%
▼	⊖	 Josh Allen	QB	\$7.3K	-25%	3%
▼	⊖	 Aaron Rodgers	QB	\$5.8K	-37%	1%
▼	⊖	 J.J. McCarthy	QB	\$4.9K	-40%	2%
▼	⊖	 Jordan Love	QB	\$6.1K	-41%	2%

So while including the obvious Chase bring-back on Bears stacks was best, if you were to galaxy-brain, it was better to swap out Chase for Puka on

Bears stacks than it was to play Chase outside of Bears stacks (which likely stems from the strong value yet modest ownership on Caleb).

When the Chalk Bring-Back Is -EV

With the Chase-Puka dilemma from Week 9 fresh on my mind and another popular bring-back decision looming in Week 10, I decided to experiment with playing a more contrarian angle. In the 100-person Luxury Box, I played a **Mac Jones** triple stack, but I opted against the obvious bring-back (**Puka Nacua**).

In this case, the sims agreed with my decision. You can see below that 10 lineups (10%) in the field played **Mac Jones**. My lineup was the only one without Nacua. Of the nine Jones stacks with a Nacua bring-back, only three of them had a post-lock sim ROI that was positive, and those were all relatively modest (all outside the top 20 ROI teams in a 100-person field). In total, both the mean and median ROIs for the Mac stacks with the chalk Puka bring-back were negative.

Week	Site - Game Type	Slate	Contest				
Week 10 - 2025	DraftKings - Classic	Sun 11/9 1:00 PM - 10 Games	\$2120 \$200K Luxury Box (100 entries) Updated 11/9 11:20 PM	Avg Sim ROI: -7.63%	Median Sim ROI: -14.52%		
RANK	POINTS	PRIZE	USER NAME	LINEUP	↓ SIM ROI	CASH RATE	
	10	186.76	\$5,000.00	leonem		41%	25%
	32	168.76		giantsquid		14%	22%
	21	177.36		papagates (1/3)		12%	22%
	28	171.16		youdacao (2/3)		11%	23%
	52	148.86		kjk003 (3/3)		-10%	19%
	12	183.36	\$4,000.00	needlunchmoney (		-19%	19%
	39	162.36		bpcolonia (1/3)		-22%	18%
	13	180.06	\$4,000.00	moklovic (2/3)		-27%	18%
	58	145.16		iliketowin21 (1/3)		-30%	17%
	11	184.36	\$4,000.00	champsarehere (2/		-46%	16%

So, why were the sims good with the chalk Caleb-Chase teams in Week 9

but not the chalk Mac-Puka teams in Week 10 (and noting that Caleb and Mac themselves had similar value rankings and field ownership)?

The smaller field magnified the ownership disparity. I was the only Mac-without-Puka lineup in the contest, compared with seven Caleb-Puka lineups in the Week 9 Game Changer. The raw number of competing lineups matters, not merely the ownership percentages.

The most important difference was that fading Puka created a meaningfully different roster construction. By fading Puka, I was able to use the extra salary to play a 3-RB team on a week with three clear Tier 1 RB values:

ALL QB RB WR TE FLEX DST					ETR - Small Field Own % Updated 11/10 6:52 PM	
					PROJECTIONS	
✓				NAME	↓ VALUE	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 De'Von Achane	4.37	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 C. McCaffrey	3.77	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 Rico Dowdle	3.6	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 Kyren Williams	1.1	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 Derrick Henry	0.76	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 T. Henderson	0.39	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 James Cook III	0.2	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 T. Etienne Jr.	0.04	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 Quinshon Judkins	-0.08	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 Breece Hall	-0.2	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 Jahmyr Gibbs	-0.36	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 Rachaad White	-0.54	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 David Montgomery	-0.67	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 K. Walker III	-0.74	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 D'Andre Swift	-0.92	
✓	🔒	🔑	RB	 Aaron Jones Sr.	-1.53	

Meanwhile, the other nine **Mac Jones** teams all had to play a double-TE lineup to fit in Puka's salary on a slate where TE offered no standout values:

ALL QB RB WR TE FLEX DST						ETR - Small Field Own %	
						Updated 11/10 6:52 PM	
						PROJECTIONS	
✓				NAME		↓ VALUE	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 Trey McBride		2.25	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 Hunter Henry		0.81	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 George Kittle		0.45	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 Cade Otton		0.37	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 Sam LaPorta		-0.11	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 Dalton Schultz		-0.44	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 Zach Ertz		-0.49	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 Mark Andrews		-0.52	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 David Njoku		-0.66	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 Dalton Kincaid OUT		-0.89	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 Juwan Johnson		-1.11	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 Theo Johnson		-1.49	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 Mason Taylor		-1.54	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 T.J. Hockenson		-1.63	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 Isaiah Likely		-1.79	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 AJ Barner		-2.14	
✓	🔒	🔑	TE	 Tyler Higbee		-2.15	

Additionally, fading Puka opened a WR spot for an additional mini-correlation: **Deebo Samuel** and **Jameson Williams**.

The key difference was what the fade accomplished beyond direct leverage.

Conclusion

This is a limited study of two small-field tournaments from two different weeks. Still, examining why the sims favored certain lineups produced several takeaways for the upcoming season:

- It's not always worth forcing the contrarian angle (fading an obvious bring-back), but it is a tool in the toolbox.
 - Adding a chalk bring-back to an existing team stack can be worthwhile, even at inflated ownership, when the player is a strong value and fits naturally within the roster construction, as Chase did in Week 9.
 - Fading a chalk bring-back can create a higher-variance lineup without sacrificing overall EV, as the Puka-over-Chase pivot did in Week 9.
 - Smaller-field tournaments may offer clearer opportunities to omit the chalk bring-back. More opponents hand-build or follow traditional correlation rules in those contests, and the smaller field allows one such decision to separate you from a meaningful portion of the lineups you need to beat.
 - The strongest bring-back fades are those that unlock a meaningful roster-construction advantage, as fading Puka did by enabling three Tier 1 RB values in Week 10.
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